Essay Structure & Terms

Concept

An essay develops one main idea through connected paragraphs. The five-paragraph model is a planning scaffold; length depends on the task.

Title

A specific name that hints at the topic or argument.

Introduction

Opens the topic and leads the reader toward the thesis.

Grabber / hook

The opening sentence or two that creates interest.

Focus statement

Introduces the general topic and useful context.

Thesis

The essay's central claim or controlling idea.

Thesis support

A reason or subclaim used to plan a body paragraph.

Topic sentence

States a paragraph's main point and connects it to the thesis.

Body paragraph

Develops one main point using evidence and explanation.

Details

Facts, examples, observations or quotations that develop a point.

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Conclusion

Brings the argument together and explains its significance.

Modified focus / thesis

Revisits the topic and main claim in fresh wording after the evidence.

Challenge

A final thought, question or action that follows from the essay.

Bridge / flow

A bridge connects ideas; flow is their overall logical continuity.

Audience / purpose

Who will read the essay, and what the writing should achieve.

Formality / tone

Formality is the level of register; tone is the attitude expressed.

Organization / diction

Organization is the arrangement of ideas; diction is word choice.

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Example 1 | original model

From topic to paragraph

Solution / why it works

1. Topic: a quiet study room. Thesis: A quiet study room would give students a dependable place for focused work.

2. Topic sentence: A reserved room would reduce interruptions during independent reading.

3. Support: Describe a realistic interruption and explain how a quiet-space rule addresses it.

4. Closing: Link fewer interruptions to the thesis about dependable study conditions.

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Essay at a glance

Opening

Grabber → focus/context → thesis.

↓

Body

Topic sentence → evidence/details → explanation → closing link.

↓

Next body paragraph(s)

Develop the next reason with the same evidence-to-explanation logic.

↓

Conclusion

Return to the topic → synthesize the claim → final thought.

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Planner | from prompt to essay

Prompt / audience / purpose / tone:

Working title + hook + focus:

Thesis + two or three supporting reasons:

Evidence and explanation for each reason:

Conclusion / final thought:

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Submission checklist | from the handout

Page setup

The source calls for white Letter paper, one-inch margins, double spacing and left-aligned text.

Typography

It recommends a readable standard 12-point font and black text. These are essay-submission directions, separate from this notebook's requested appearance.

Heading and header

First-page heading: student, teacher, course and date. Running header: surname and page number at the top right, if assigned.

Paragraphs

Use a consistent first-line indent, normally half an inch; use paragraph settings rather than repeated spaces.

Final review

Check thesis, evidence, organization, transitions, grammar, spelling and punctuation. Follow your teacher's specific formatting requirements.

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Practice | your turn

1. Write a hook, focus statement and thesis for a school improvement.

2. Plan two body paragraphs with different reasons.

3. Write a conclusion that synthesizes rather than copies the introduction.

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Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

Hook attracts interest; focus gives context; thesis states the specific claim.

2

Each paragraph needs a distinct reason, relevant support and an explanation.

3

Restate the insight in new words, connect the reasons and end with a proportionate final thought.

Source & editing note

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